

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

Go / No-Go Decision Template

Run a fast, fair release decision meeting where the risk is clear and the accountability is explicit.

Purpose

A go/no-go template turns the release decision from a hallway conversation into a short, structured meeting with a clear record. It gathers the people who own the risk, checks a small set of criteria, surfaces residual risk honestly, and produces a decision with a named owner. The point is not to slow releases down — it is to make the decision defensible and to stop QA from being the accidental scapegoat when a release goes wrong.

When to use it

- Before any release significant enough that a bad outcome would matter to customers or the business.
- When multiple squads or stakeholders must align — as at Northstar, where each squad releases on its own cadence with no shared quality gate.
- Whenever a release is contested (product wants speed, engineering wants more automation, QA sees residual risk).
- As a lightweight recurring ritual so the decision is a habit, not a crisis.

Instructions

1. Circulate the release risk assessment before the meeting, not during it. The meeting is for the decision, not the reading.
2. Confirm the decision owner (the accountable person) and the advisers (QA on risk, engineering on technical readiness, product on business need).
3. Walk the criteria checklist and mark each Red, Amber or Green with evidence, not opinion.
4. State residual risk and confidence in one or two sentences each.
5. Take the decision: Go, Go with conditions, or No-Go. If conditions, list them as blockers with owners.
6. Record it: who decided, what was known, what was accepted, and who owns each follow-up. Distribute it.

Worked example

The Payments checkout v2.3 decision from the release risk assessment, run as a go/no-go with Priya Nadar (VP Engineering, decision owner), the QA lead, Marcus Lee (Payments squad lead) and Tom Fielding (Head of

Product).

Criterion	Status	Evidence
All Critical and High risks tested or mitigated	Amber	Two High risks remain, both with concrete mitigations agreed
No open critical defects	Green	None open against this release
Regression of impacted areas complete	Amber	Impacted areas covered; load and reconciliation paths not exercised
Rollback tested and fast	Green	Feature flag rollback rehearsed, under 15 minutes
Monitoring and alerting in place	Amber	Capture-without-order alert to be enabled before release — a condition
Environment / test-data confidence	Red	Shared staging unstable through half the window; confidence reduced
Stakeholders informed of residual risk	Green	This meeting; on-call owner briefed

Decision record	Value
Residual risk	High, concentrated in the capture-to-order and billing-write paths
Confidence	Medium, limited by staging instability
Decision	Go with conditions
Conditions (blockers)	Flagged 5% rollout; capture-without-order alert live; reconciliation report at +1h and +24h; named on-call owner; rehearsed rollback
Decision owner	Priya Nadar (VP Engineering)
What was explicitly accepted	Untested behaviour under concurrent load, mitigated by staged rollout and monitoring
Review point	Reconciliation report reviewed at +24h before widening the rollout

Everyone leaves knowing the same thing: it is shipping, but narrowly and watched, and the accepted risk is on the record with the person who accepted it. Marcus, sceptical of QA, sees QA enabling the release rather than blocking it — which does more for QA's credibility than any test-case count.

Blank reusable version

Criterion	Status (R/A/G)	Evidence
All Critical and High risks tested or mitigated		
No open critical defects		
Regression of impacted areas complete		
Rollback tested and fast		
Monitoring and alerting in place		
Environment / test-data confidence		

Criterion	Status (R/A/G)	Evidence
Stakeholders informed of residual risk		

Decision record	Value
Residual risk	
Confidence	High / Medium / Low
Decision	Go / Go with conditions / No-Go
Conditions (blockers)	
Decision owner	
What was explicitly accepted	
Review point	

Common mistakes

COMMON MISTAKES

Letting QA "make the call" — QA advises on risk, the accountable owner decides; running the meeting as a rubber stamp where Red items are talked away without action; marking criteria on opinion rather than evidence; producing no written record, so nobody can reconstruct what was known; and treating every release as needing the full ceremony, which trains people to skip it.

- Inviting people who cannot decide and excluding the one who can.
- Accepting risk verbally without recording who accepted it and what exactly they accepted.

How to interpret the results

- Any Red on a Critical/High-risk criterion should force either a No-Go or a specific, owned mitigation — never a shrug.
- A row of Ambers with real mitigations is a healthy "Go with conditions"; a row of Ambers with no mitigations is a No-Go wearing optimism.
- The value is in the record. Six months later, the decision log is what protects the team and improves the next decision.
- If the same criterion is Red release after release (for Northstar, environment stability), that is a systemic problem to escalate, not a per-release nuisance.
- Right-size the ceremony: a small, low-risk change needs a two-minute async check; a payments change needs the full meeting.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

The decision owner is never QA. Your job is to make the risk impossible to misunderstand and then hand the decision to the person accountable for the outcome. Do this consistently and you convert QA from "the

team that blocks releases" into "the team that lets us ship with our eyes open" — a reputation worth far more than a veto.